

Psalms 85

Mercy and Truth Are Met Together

Mercy and truth are met together; righteousness and peace have kissed each other

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 LORD, thou hast been favourable unto thy land: thou hast brought back the captivity of Jacob.
- 2 Thou hast forgiven the iniquity of thy people, thou hast covered all their sin. Selah.
- 3 Thou hast taken away all thy wrath: thou hast turned thyself from the fierceness of thine anger.
- 4 Turn us, O God of our salvation, and cause thine anger toward us to cease.
- 5 Wilt thou be angry with us for ever? wilt thou draw out thine anger to all generations?
- 6 Wilt thou not revive us again: that thy people may rejoice in thee?
- 7 Shew us thy mercy, O LORD, and grant us thy salvation.
- 8 I will hear what God the LORD will speak: for he will speak peace unto his people, and to his saints: but let them not turn again to folly.
- 9 Surely his salvation is nigh them that fear him; that glory may dwell in our land.
- 10 Mercy and truth are met together; righteousness and peace have kissed each other.
- 11 Truth shall spring out of the earth; and righteousness shall look down from heaven.
- 12 Yea, the LORD shall give that which is good; and our land shall yield her increase.
- 13 Righteousness shall go before him; and shall set us in the way of his steps.

2 · CONTEXT

A psalm that moves from grateful memory of past restoration, through present petition for renewed favor, to a prophetic vision of reconciled righteousness and peace. It likely reflects a season after judgment or exile when the nation has tasted some relief but still awaits full restoration. Henry highlights the psalm's structure as a model for prayer: remember what God has done, ask honestly for what is still needed, then listen for what God will say in response.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The psalm opens in remembered grace: God has been favorable to the land, has brought back the captivity of Jacob, has forgiven the people's iniquity and covered all their sin, turning away His wrath and fierce anger. Past mercy is recounted specifically and gratefully before any new request is made.

Verse 4-7

Present need is then voiced honestly: turn us again, God of our salvation, and cause your anger toward us to cease. The question 'will you be angry with us forever' captures real uncertainty, followed by direct requests—revive us again, show us your mercy, grant us your salvation.

Verse 8-13

The psalmist resolves to listen for what God will say, anticipating a word of peace to His people if they do not return to folly, since salvation is near for those who fear Him. The psalm rises to its climactic vision: mercy and truth meeting together, righteousness and peace kissing each other, truth springing up from the earth while righteousness looks down from heaven. The Lord gives what is good, the land yields its increase, and righteousness itself goes before Him, preparing the way for His steps.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Genuine prayer holds together grateful memory of God's past mercy, honest present petition for what is still lacking, and expectant listening for God's response—not merely a one-directional list of requests. The psalm's vision of mercy, truth, righteousness, and peace united together pictures full reconciliation, not a partial or compromised peace, as the ultimate goal of God's restoring work.

Application for life today.

Structure your own prayer, especially in a season of partial restoration, along this psalm's pattern: recount specific past mercies, voice present need honestly, then deliberately pause to listen rather than rushing to the next request. Consider where in your life

'mercy and truth' or 'righteousness and peace' currently feel at odds rather than united, and pray specifically for that reconciliation. Let verse 13's image—righteousness going before God, preparing His way—shape how you expect His guidance to arrive.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What specific past mercy from God do you need to recount gratefully before voicing a new request, as this psalm models (vv. 1–3)?

2. Where in your life do mercy and truth, or righteousness and peace, currently feel at odds rather than 'kissing each other' (v. 10)?

3. What would it look like to actually pause and 'hear what God the Lord will speak' (v. 8) rather than only presenting requests?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).